GAME DECONSTRUCTION · CASUAL MATCH-3

Royal Match

Dream Games (Istanbul) · soft launch July 2020, global launch February 25, 2021 · Unity · iOS and Android · no ads.

$1.4B+
in-app revenue in 2025, one of the three top-grossing mobile games (Sensor Tower)

$0.17
IAP revenue per daily active user, second highest among top match-3 games (Naavik)

12,400+
levels by November 2025, released on a steady cadence

The one-paragraph read

Royal Match did not invent a new mechanic. It took the proven match-3 formula and made every part of it **faster, clearer and more generous**: bigger pieces, very fast swaps, power-ups that clear more than rivals' and even retarget themselves. It removed what slows a player down (a full decoration meta) and kept a light one: stars from levels buy tasks in King Robert's castle. Revenue comes almost only from coins spent on extra moves at the end of a failed level, so level design *is* monetisation design. I chose it because it is the benchmark for my own genre: my match-3, Arcana Match, faces the same design questions at a much smaller scale. In mid-2023 it passed Candy Crush as the world's top-grossing mobile game; in 2025 CVC Capital Partners valued Dream Games at $5 billion.

Three things I take away

1. Execution beats novelty. Speed, clarity and generosity in the core are a competitive advantage that is hard to copy because it lives in hundreds of small tuning decisions, not in a feature list.

2. The loss screen is the store. One currency, one main purchase (5 more moves) and levels tuned to end "almost won". Everything else in the economy supports that moment.

3. Live ops add variety, not complexity. Dozens of events reuse the same levels with a new goal, a new group size or a first-try rule. Each is learnable in seconds.

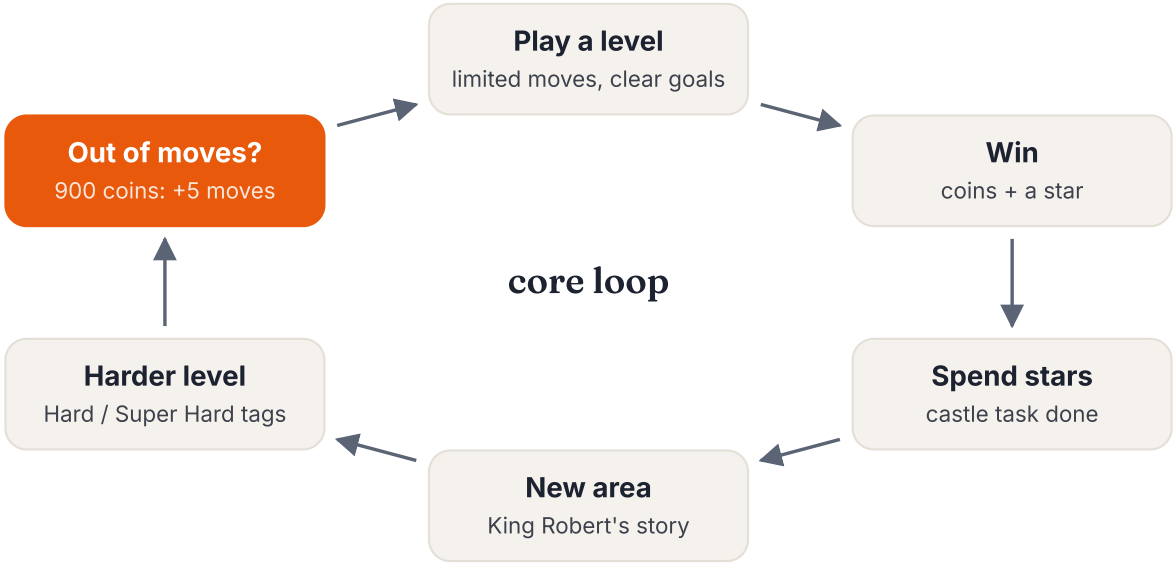
Inside

1	**Core loop and feel**	Power-ups, the small decisions that make it feel fast, and its place among match-3 games
2	**Level design and monetisation**	Near misses, the escalating extra-moves offer, one currency
3	**Live ops**	30+ event types in five families, and the revenue each added
4	**Proposals and comparison**	Two tests, and what I learned for my own match-3, Arcana Match

Method. Desk research from public sources only: store listings, the developer's help center, press coverage, Sensor Tower estimates, industry analyses (Naavik, Deconstructor of Fun) and player reviews. I have no internal data, so every statement about KPIs is a hypothesis, marked as such. Sources are listed on the last page. Written September 2026.

1 · CORE LOOP AND FEEL

A familiar loop, tuned to feel faster than anyone else's



Orange marks the main monetisation moment. Losing costs a life (5 maximum, 1 back every 30 minutes; 8 maximum with the Royal Pass).

Power-ups

MATCH	CREATES
4 in a line	Rocket (clears a row or column)
2 × 2 square	Propeller (flies to a goal)
L or T shape	TNT (area blast)
5 in a line	Light Ball (clears one colour)

Combining two power-ups multiplies the effect. Pre-level boosters and in-level tools (Royal Hammer, Arrow, Cannon, Jester's Hat) sit on top.

Small decisions that add up

- **Concurrent matching:** you can move while a cascade is still falling, so the board never makes you wait.
- **Smart propellers** retarget mid-flight if their goal is already gone, so a power-up is never wasted.
- **No forced activation:** power-ups are never triggered for you when no other move exists.
- **Self-counting obstacles** (mailboxes, top hats) switch off when their goal is met, so the player never counts.
- **Butler's Gift:** winning up to 3 levels in a row puts up to 3 power-ups on the next board: a streak that rewards without punishing a break too hard.

Design read. Every item on this list removes a small moment of friction or confusion. None of them would sell a game alone; together they make Royal Match feel better in the first ten seconds of play than competitors with bigger feature lists.

Where it sits among match-3 games

MODEL	EXAMPLE	META	ROYAL MATCH'S CHOICE
Classic saga	Candy Crush Saga	A map of levels	Kept the saga map
Puzzle and decorate	Homescapes, Gardenscapes	Story, choices, heavy decoration	Took a "lite" version: tasks, no choices
Team-first blast	Toon Blast	Teams and team events	Took the team focus

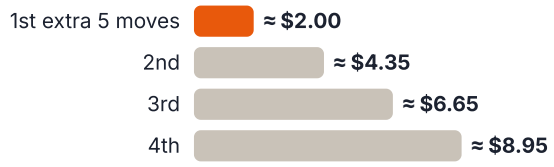
Analysts call the result "social/decorative lite": the simplicity of Coin Master's building meta and the team focus of Toon Blast, on a classic switcher core.

Levels tuned to end "almost won"

How difficulty is framed

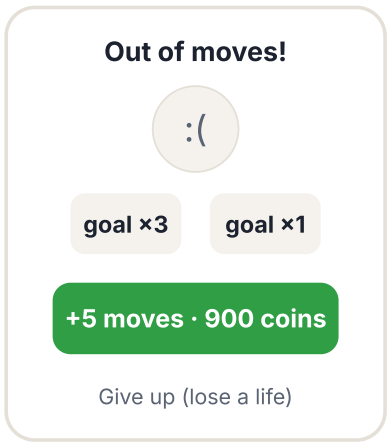
- **Labels set expectations.** Levels are tagged *Hard* or *Super Hard* before you start, so a loss feels like the level's fault and a win feels earned.
- **Near misses by design.** Analysts describe levels built to end just short: close enough that 5 more moves feel worth buying.
- **Generous peaks.** Even Super Hard levels can be won with many moves left when power-ups combine well, so skill and luck both show.
- **Variety comes from obstacles,** not new rules; an early critique (Deconstructor of Fun, 2021) was that goals were mostly "clear the board", which the huge later level count has broadened.

The escalating extra-moves offer



Dollar value of the coins each consecutive "+5 moves" costs within one attempt (Naavik's analysis). The first offer was the most expensive in the genre at the time; each repeat costs more.

The end-of-round screen



Schematic, not a screenshot. Dream Games A/B-tested this screen until it showed only what matters: the goals still missing, King Robert's sad face with a big zero, and the offer. Even the goals sit next to the coin balance. It is ruthless, but it is also honest: the player sees exactly what they are buying.

One currency, few offers

ELEMENT	ROLE
Coins (only currency)	Extra moves, lives, boosters; earned from wins, bonus levels (300–700 coins) and events
Lives	Pace play and create a natural return point every few hours; teams can send lives
Royal Pass (monthly, 30 steps)	Priced above $10 when rivals charged $5–6; adds status (golden profile frame) and more lives. At launch it lifted revenue 31% and D30 retention 2%
No ads	Keeps the experience premium and protects trust; all revenue from IAP

Design read. Because revenue comes from one moment, the whole game is tuned around it. That is efficient but fragile: when a level feels impossible rather than close, the same screen reads as a paywall. Store reviews mention players replaying one level "50 to 100 times".

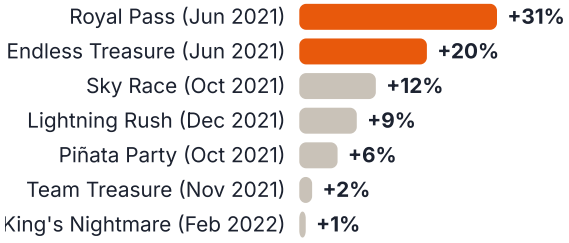
3 · LIVE OPS

Dozens of events, each learnable in seconds

The help center lists more than 30 event types. Almost all reuse normal levels and change only **who you compete with**, **what you collect** or **what a loss costs**. That makes new events cheap to build and easy to understand.

FAMILY	EXAMPLES (GROUP SIZE)	PLAYER MOTIVE
Solo competition	King's Cup (50 players), Sky Race (5, first to 15 levels), Lightning Rush (5, one hour, unlimited lives), Archery Arena (50), Robot Rivals (1 vs 1), Champions Clash (8, knock-out)	Status, urgency
Team competition	Team Battle and Team Tournament (20 teams), Royal Cup (100 countries)	Belonging, obligation
Streak / first try	Lava Quest (7 first-try wins in a row), Space Mission, Ancient Adventure	Tension; raises the value of boosters
Collection	Book of Treasure, Propeller Madness, Balloon Rise, card collection	Steady goals while playing normally
Co-op and minigames	Team Treasure, Train Journey (3 partners), Dragon Nest, Merge Smith, Magic Cauldron	Variety, a break from the core

Revenue lift at each event's launch



Revenue change reported by Naavik for each event's release (2021–22). King's Nightmare also lifted D14 retention by 3%.

Why layering works

- Several events run at once, so every level played counts toward something.
- Short events (Lightning Rush: one hour) create peaks of play; long ones (Royal Pass: a month) give a steady reason to return.
- Unlimited-lives windows remove the pacing limit exactly when competition makes players want to play more, which moves spending to coins and boosters instead of lives.
- Team events bring social obligation to a game with a very light meta.

Design read. The order matters: Dream Games launched with the core and a thin event layer, then added roughly one event every month or two, measuring each one. The lesson for a small team is to ship the core polished and grow live ops by data, not to launch with everything.

4 · PROPOSALS AND COMPARISON

What I would test, and what I learned for my own game

PROPOSAL 1 A one-use shield for first-try events

Lava Quest-style events wipe all progress after a single loss. That creates tension, but a loss at 6 of 7 is also a common rage-quit moment. Offer one shield per event (a Royal Pass step reward, or a small coin purchase) that saves the streak once.

Hypothesis	A shield reduces quits after a late-streak loss and adds a new, low-friction coin sink.
Test	A/B during 2 Lava Quest runs, split by player ID.
Primary	Sessions in the 24 hours after a streak loss; event completion rate; coin spend per event.
Guardrails	Extra-moves purchases during the event (should not fall); event must still feel hard.

PROPOSAL 2 A welcome-back ramp using Butler's Gift

Players returning after 7+ days often land on a hard level, the worst first impression. Give returning players a full Butler's Gift (3 power-ups) for their first 3 levels. It reuses an existing system, so no new content is needed.

Hypothesis	Early wins after a break raise reactivation retention.
Test	A/B on players inactive 7+ days; 4 weeks.
Primary	D7 retention after return; levels played in the first returning session.
Guardrails	Payer conversion of returners; no drop for players who did not leave (they are not in the test).

Royal Match next to my Arcana Match

	ROYAL MATCH	ARCANA MATCH (MY DESIGN)	WHAT I TAKE FROM THE COMPARISON
Pacing	Lives: 5, one per 30 minutes	No energy system, by choice	Lives also create return moments; I would need another return driver (my daily draw does this)
Extra moves	Coins, escalating price	Planned: +5 moves once per attempt, rewarded ad or small purchase	My single offer is kinder but earns less; escalation is the lever to test
Difficulty tuning	Data from millions of players, A/B tests	A bot that plays the real rules, 60 games per level	A bot finds walls before launch; live data tunes the "almost won" feel after
Streaks	Butler's Gift rewards streaks	Daily draw with no streak to lose	Both avoid punishing a break too hard
Difficulty labels	Hard / Super Hard tags	None yet	I would add them: cheap, and they change how a loss feels

Bottom line. Royal Match shows that a small team (Dream Games had under 80 people when valued at $2.75B) can win a crowded genre by polishing the core and letting data decide what to add. That is the approach I try to practise at my scale.

Sources

1. Wikipedia, "Royal Match": release dates, engine, boosters, level count (Nov 2025), early revenue, funding rounds, Royal Kingdom.
2. Naavik, "Royal Match: Dream Games' Regal Performance" (deep dive): extra-move pricing, end-of-round screen, event launch timeline and revenue lifts, Royal Pass pricing, valuation per employee.
3. Naavik, "What leading match-3 and merge games do differently": 2025 IAP revenue, ARPDAU, no ads.
4. Deconstructor of Fun, "Royal Match: The New King from Turkey?" (March 2021): switcher feel, power-up behaviour, 900-coin extra moves, bonus levels, level-design critique.
5. Royal Match Help Center (Dream Games), "Events and tournaments" and "Lives": event list and group sizes, lives and refill time.
6. MENAbytes, "Dream Games valued at $5 billion" (May 2025): CVC deal, 2023 revenue and marketing spend.
7. Sensor Tower blog: top match-3 games in the US, Q1 and Q3 2025; 2025 revenue ranking.
8. Apple App Store listing and aggregated player reviews (AppGamer, Apple Community) for sentiment.

Revenue and usage figures are third-party estimates or company statements reported in the press. Event revenue lifts come from one analyst's 2021–22 data and show the direction of each effect rather than exact current values.